

Absence Makes the Heart Grow Fonder

1 Thessalonians 3:9-13

How can we thank God enough for you in return for all the joy we have in the presence of our God because of you? Night and day we pray most earnestly that we may see you again and supply what is lacking in your faith. Now may our God and Father himself and our Lord Jesus clear the way for us to come to you. May the Lord make your love increase and overflow for each other and for everyone else, just as ours does for you. May he strengthen your hearts so that you will be blameless and holy in the presence of our God and Father when our Lord Jesus comes with all his holy ones.

In the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit. Amen.

“Absence makes the heart grow fonder” is a phrase that has been around for so long because it’s true! Absence DOES make the heart grow fonder. It means that if you are far away from someone, you will miss them; even though it’s hard to miss someone, it’s proof that you love them. Your heart might ache because you don’t get to see that person, but that heartache tells you something about the way you feel about them.

When Paul wrote these words, he was describing that feeling. He missed the Thessalonian church and wanted to be with them. His heart hurt for them, but that hurt was a blessing that reminded him just how thankful he was for those people. What hurt perhaps the most is that he wasn’t sure if he would see the Thessalonians again.

Paul missing the Thessalonians reminded him of someone else he had not seen in a while, someone else he was missing. That person was Jesus. But while Paul didn’t know if he was going to get to see the Thessalonians again in this life, he knew two things: 1) He knew he would see every single member of that congregation again in heaven, and 2) He knew that he would see Jesus again at his second coming and for the rest of eternity.

We might not be in the Thessalonian church that Paul was writing to, but we know what it’s like to miss people that we love and what it’s like to wait for Jesus to arrive. So, we can listen to Paul’s encouragement to that congregation and be confident in the same things: we will one day be reunited with all our brothers and sisters in Christ because we know that Jesus is on his way to take us to be home with him forever.

In the meantime, it’s okay to let absence make the heart grow fonder. We will take Paul’s prayer to heart, “May the Lord make your love increase and overflow for each other and everyone else . . . may he strengthen your hearts so that you will be blameless and holy in the presence of our God and Father when our Lord Jesus comes.”

The questions below are to help families discuss this devotion. The questions are divided by age group as suggestions, but anyone could reflect on any of the questions as they desire.

Questions for the Younger Children

- Who is someone that you are looking forward to seeing again?
- When will we get to see Jesus again?

Questions for Elementary Age Children

- Think of someone that you miss and fill in the blank: "I can't wait to be with _____ again!"
- Think of how Jesus feels about you and fill in the blank: "Jesus can't wait to be with _____ again!"

Questions for Middle School and Above

- What is a time in your life that you really felt the phrase "absence makes the heart grow fonder"?
- We know Jesus isn't really "absent," but how is the statement still true about our relationship with Christ?

Closing Prayer:

Lord Jesus, although we cannot see you with our eyes, we know that you are with us every single day. Until you come again, make our hearts grow fonder and increase our love for one another. In your name we ask it. Amen.